Soviets as one transporting missiles and was thus supposed to be exempt from inspection. It was approached, however, wrote Wellborn, because the number of missiles provided by the other ships was not exact, and the American commanders decided to check the *Aleksandrovsk* as well.[29]

During the first ten days of November, General Statsenko managed to ship forty-two missiles, 1,056 pieces of equipment, and 3,289 officers and men back to the Soviet Union. The last ship to carry R-12 missiles left Cuba from the port of Casilda on November 9, the day the new inspection regulations went into effect. It was the Soviet-built dry cargo ship *Leninskii Komsomol*, on its second trip to Cuba, that took a load of eight R-12 missiles and 320 officers and men under the command of Lieutenant Colonel Feliks Khachaturov, the deputy commander of Ivan Sidorov's regiment, whose missiles had been the first to arrive in Cuba. The missiles on board the *Leninskii Komsomol* were inspected and photographed on the same day as the USS *Norfolk*.[30]

Igor Statsenko later reported that during the second stage of the evacuation of his division from Cuba, which lasted from November 18 to December 12, 3,716 men and 985 pieces of weaponry and equipment were loaded on twelve ships and sent back to the Soviet Union. Colonel Sidorov, whose R-12 ballistic missile regiment was the first to reach Cuba in August, was among the last rocket men to leave the island. "I left Cuba with the last naval echelon in mid-December 1962," he recalled. "Our echelon boarded the *Atkarsk* in the port of Cienfuegos, but the destination port was no longer Sevastopol but Baltiisk." If on the way to Cuba the soldiers had sweltered in the heat of the tween decks, they now froze in the cold of the approaches to the Baltic Sea. They were going back to Baltiisk and not Sevastopol for one simple reason: all nuclear warheads were shipped out and then returned to the Soviet Union through that port, and the *Atkarsk* was full of them.[31]

On the Soviet side, for the next few decades the story of the Soviet withdrawal from Cuba would be a secret history, full of silence, confusion, conflicting memories, and, last but not least, humiliation.